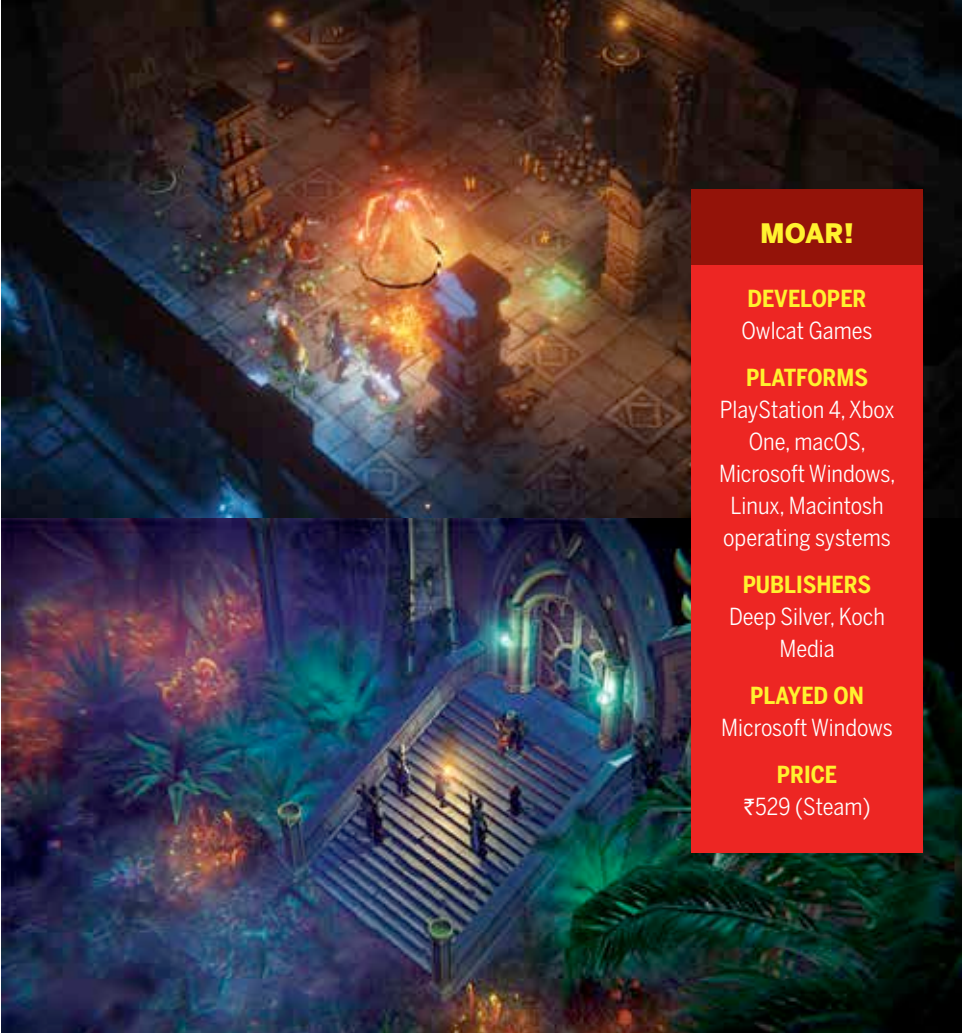




MOAR!

DEVELOPER

Owlcat Games

PLATFORMS

PlayStation 4, Xbox One, macOS, Microsoft Windows, Linux, Macintosh operating systems

PUBLISHERS

Deep Silver, Koch Media

PLAYED ON

Microsoft Windows

PRICE

₹529 (Steam)

the alignment for your character during character creation, however, as you play the game, your alignment can shift depending on the actions you take. Your alignment also comes into play during speech checks, opening up new options or closing off others. The game gives a lot of importance to dialogue, and you'll be doing a lot of it; being able to talk your way out of a situation can be both handy and rewarding, as the game gives you experience for picking non-violent solutions as well.

Throughout your playthrough you will meet plenty of colorful and memorable companions, many of whom can even be missed if you don't bother exploring the game's world. Among the first companions you meet are the likes of Amiri, a barbarian who believes actions speak louder than just about anything else, Linzi, a bard who also happens to be the one narrating and journaling your story, Har-rim, a cleric who believes the world is coming to an end soon, and many more. There are a total of 13 companions in the game, including the DLC.

GAMEPLAY

The controls are simple: Space to pause combat, R to rest, hold down tab to highlight interactable objects. Once you've selected a character, or your party, you can left or right click on the map or on enemies to make them attack or move. You've got your action bar at the bottom, with expansions to the bar on the left side of the screen as the number of abilities you have grows. On lower difficulties, with a general idea of what's going on, you can pretty much run into a room and point-and-click your way to victory, like an RTS game. Bumping the difficulty up, even to just normal, will require you to do a whole lot more preparation, strategising, and pausing before and during encounters in order to succeed. The game has a turn-based mode as well, which players of games like Divinity: Original Sin 2 might be more familiar with, but do note that it slows the game down significantly, since it was initially designed to be played in real-time. Turn-based mode does work just fine though. Some parts of the game will

take place on the pages of a book, where you read through the encounter and are prompted with the actions you can take at the bottom. They're accompanied by beautiful illustrations to portray what's happening. They're fairly uncommon and serve as a nice break from the usual top-down gameplay. Throughout the game you will come across various skill checks, the most common of them being perception which allows you to spot traps and potential loot. You'll also come across areas, like shortcuts, where you will need mobility or athletics checks, disarming traps is a trickery check and so on. Fortunately, the game will automatically pick the party member with the highest score for that check, which incentivises having a well-rounded party.

Finally, we come to Kingdom management, the part where you actually manage your kingdom. This is something you can skip entirely if you so please and have the game do it for you automatically. However, if you decide to be hands-on and do it yourself, there's a LOT to do. Here you will be able to annex new lands, establish new towns, build them up, and set tasks for your advisors. Your alignment here dictates the buildings you can build and some actions you can take. It's certainly no full-blown management sim, but it's still a unique feature to the game. Unfortunately, it plays a very insignificant role compared to the time you spend on it. You could pretty much skip it entirely and not have it affect the end result.

VERDICT

Pathfinder: Kingmaker has some aspects that are unique to the genre, but doesn't otherwise stand out too much. The writing is solid, with a gripping story and well written characters, and the visuals are pretty good too. Unfortunately, Kingmaker was not good enough to make it stand out amongst its contemporaries, but it's still a decent game nonetheless. Wrath of the Righteous however looks to be shaking things up, and we're definitely excited to give it a try. *